nationalist agenda in Rakhine State against the NLD, while favouring those identified with the communal sentiments. The religiously based antagonism was particularly significant because Rakhine ethnicity is articulated in terms of Buddhism (de Mersan 2015, p. 46; Leider 2008). Both ethno-nationalism and Buddhist nationalism that dominated pre-election discussions seemed to have converged to give the ANP electoral dominance in Rakhine State. The relevance of Rakhine ethno-nationalism is that the ANP portrayed itself as the vanguard of the Rakhine ethnic movement. The influence of Buddhist nationalism in Rakhine State also meant that those candidates who identified with anti-Muslim sentiments would have done well in the township where communal conflicts were more severe and religious antagonism was intense. The ANP's background and the detailed voting patterns at the township or constituency level show the strength and characteristics of Rakhine ethno-nationalism and Buddhist nationalism in Rakhine State during the 2015 election.

The ANP, through its leaders and formation process, has come to be not just a political party representing people of Rakhine ethnicity, but also the party working for the aspirations of ethno-nationalism, especially Arakanese (the former name of Rakhine State) sovereignty. The ANP itself is relatively young. It was only officially established in April 2014. However it has a long history, since it was formed through the merger of two existing Rakhine political parties, namely the Arakan League for Democracy (ALD), formed in 1989, and the Rakhine Nationalities Development Party (RNDP), formed in 2009. The merger discussions started early in 2012 (Ei Ei Toe Lwin 2012), however the actual dissolution of each party and establishment of a single leadership mechanism only occurred in February 2014, with official registration in March 2014.

The ALD was the most prominent Arakanese political party in the 1990 election, winning the third largest number of seats (eleven) at the national level, one more than the junta-backed National Unity Party. The most significant ALD politician during its 1990 electoral campaign was the late U Oo Tha Tun,[3] the champion of Arakanese sovereignty and ancient Arakanese history. After 1990, the ALD was driven underground and was limited to a few public activities around the involvement of its new leader, U Aye Thar Aung, in national politics as General Secretary of the Committee Representing the People's Parliament (CRPP), in close collaboration with the NLD. The ALD also joined the NLD-led 2010 election boycott, but re-registered in 2012.